



Contributing Shluchim: Rabbis Sholom Duchman, Shaul Perlstein, Shaya Deitsch, Mendy Browstein, Sholom Ber Simon

HOW DO I OVERCOME THE FEAR OF ASKING FOR MONEY?

We’ve all experienced the anxiety. That first phone call; hesitantly dialing each number. Facing each other awkwardly during the first meeting; worrying if he misunderstood your last joke. After you’ve left, you can’t help wondering, “Did he like it? Will he see me again?”

You bring the family a challah, maybe have them over for a meal. Slowly, as you become friends, they gradually increase their Yiddishkeit practices. But still you wonder, “Should I ask him yet, or should I get to know him better? What or exactly how much should I ask for?”

Fundraising is a most nerve-racking experience. Why do we fear fundraising, and how do we overcome that anxiety?

Rabbi Sholom Duchman in Brooklyn, NY, claims even veterans are not immune to the fear. “Even after 30 years, there are still times I lose confidence. Once, on the way to a meeting on 63rd street, I got cold feet. At 34th street, I got off the train and returned home.”

One of the primary reasons we dread fundraising is the fear of rejection. While this universal emotion is not unique to shluchim, **Rabbi Eliyahu Schusterman** (Atlanta, GA), says that Shlichus itself is what provides the solution. “When you understand your goals and keep in mind what you set out to accomplish, you realize that the donor is not doing you a favor, but it is rather you who is providing him or her with the opportunity of being a part of the Rebbe’s mission.”

“Aside from the very real difference he makes to your shlichus, making him a true partner in your work, tzedoko itself is one of the mitzvot!”

Rabbi Shaul Perlstein, Shliach in Chattanooga, TN, says that at times one may feel uncomfortable with the “product” they are offering. “When your shiur attracts “only” five people, it may be tough to ask someone to sponsor your activities,” he says. “Being cognizant of the Rebbe’s mission and appreciating the value of each of those five neshamos infuses a shliach with the necessary confidence to pull through.”

DOES MONEY RUIN FRIENDSHIPS?

Another reason for trepidation is the worry of ruining a relationship. “We’re good friends,” you might think, “I don’t want him to think I’m just interested in his money.” **Rabbi Shaya Deitsch** Shliach in Montgomery County, PA, says it is best to be up front. “When asking for a donation, I make it clear that the relationship means more than the money. I find that it not only brings to greater success, it breeds confidence.” Deitsch tells of a doctor who he befriended for years without asking for a donation. “I didn’t want him to think all I wanted was his money, yet I worried constantly that that was all he was thinking anyway.”

When Deitsch finally asked for support, instead of being harmed, their bond strengthened. “It was like a weight was lifted off my shoulders. I no longer fretted over imaginary conceptions.”

IT’S NOT ABOUT THE MONEY

“It’s not about dollars. It’s about impact,” says Duchman. When approaching a potential donor—and perhaps more importantly, in your own mind—it is essential to portray the impact the donation will have rather than money needed. “I don’t fundraise; I feed poor people,” says Duchman.

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Deitsch relates that a supporter once gave \$12,000, saying, “I’m giving this specifically because you are not about the money.”

“If your relationship is based solely on money — something finite — it’s doomed to failure,” claims Schusterman. “True, you may reach out to someone with fundraising in mind, but when you’re with them, it’s the infinite power of shlichus that takes over.”

“Take, for example, that gvir you learned with for half an hour yesterday. Over the past year he may put on tefillin occasionally, put mezuzos on his office doors, bentch lulav, learn a few times a week, or send his kids to Gan Israel. His growth in Yiddishkeit is all because you needed money.”

JUST DO IT

“How do we overcome the anxiety?” asks **Rabbi Mendy Brownstein** of Chabad of Oyster Bay, NY, “I wish I knew,” he grins. “Certainly, the Shliach

sets the atmosphere. If I walk in confidently, proud of my shlichus, the feeling will spread. ‘A Chossid macht a svivah.’”

“At the end of the day,” says Duchman. “difficult as it is, the only real way to break through the fear is to just go out and fundraise. *L’hatchillah Aribet*.”

“I call nine people expecting nine ‘nos’ so that I can get to the tenth who says, ‘yes,’” says **Rabbi Sholom Ber Simon**, of the Jewish Children’s Museum. “Every ‘no’ gets me closer to the ‘yes’. How can I not like them?”

What keeps Brownstein ticking, is the quintessential Shlichus story. “My wife and I were knocking on doors at an office park distributing menorahs for Chanukah. We were rejected at every turn. About to give up, we knocked on the door of one final law firm, where we met a lawyer who said sternly, ‘Let me guess why you’re here.’ But then rather than berate us, he broke out into a big smile and warmly welcomed us.” Steven is now a close friend of Chabad.

“True, I am refused time after time,” says Mendy, “but as I keep plugging away, I think to myself, ‘who knows; another Steven may be just around the corner.’”

המעשה הוא העיקר

- **LEARNING TORAH** To be sure, learning is vital for every Yid, especially Shluchim, for a host of reasons. However the side benefits of learning in terms of fundraising are remarkable. Keep your head in the books, and you’ll always have something to say.
- **ASEH LECHO RAV** Once again, this is a key directive of the Rebbe that literally pays dividends. Having someone to talk to before or after a fundraising call can calm the nerves, put you in the right frame of mind, and ensure you are ‘mission oriented’.
- **BUDGET** Having a detailed budget not only shows accountability, making your Chabad House an appealing investment, it serves as a confidence boost for the Shliach. Knowing that when you are questioned, you have what to answer, allays much of the fear of fundraising.